

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MADAGASCAR

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around the lever that drove a gold company out of Soamahamanina — a farming community's sustained, disciplined refusal, which marched every week, drew national and international attention, and would not be moved — and it names the tools you'll meet (the sustained refusal, the national and UN attention, the question of a license's provenance, the land-and-livelihood case) in plain words. It is written with care, because defenders here have met tear gas and arrest.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In 2016, the people of **Soamahamanina** — a commune of some fourteen thousand west of the capital — learned that a Chinese firm, **Jiuxing Mines**, had been handed a **forty-year license** to mine gold across **seventy-five hundred hectares** of their land: the rice fields and hills their families had farmed, and been buried in, for generations. They did not accept it. Week after week, **every Thursday, they marched**. When security forces met them with tear gas and arrested their leaders, they kept marching — and the arrests only drew national attention and a **United Nations human-rights rapporteur**. By July the **government had halted the project**, and by October the company announced it would pull out; the Chinese management left Soamahamanina, abandoning their tents. A farming community with nothing but its unity and its refusal had driven out a foreign mining company and forced its own government to stop the mine.

The people of Soamahamanina drove out a foreign gold miner with a sustained, disciplined refusal — marching every Thursday until the government halted the mine — and the same lever suspended the Base Toliara mineral-sands project three years later; the tools around it are available to communities across Madagascar. **National and international attention** — the press, a UN human-rights rapporteur, human-rights and environmental bodies — magnifies a refusal and shields it. The **question of a license's provenance** — a permit issued by an illegitimate or transitional regime, on unfavourable terms, as Base Toliara's 2012 licence was — is a real vulnerability. The **land-and-livelihood case** — the rice fields, the ancestral ground — is a powerful argument. And the **courts**, where they function, can be tried; protest and petition are lawful, though defenders must weigh the real risk. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. Defenders here have faced **tear gas and arrest**, so this guide treats safety with care. Madagascar is **one of the world's poorest countries**, its institutions weak and its rule of law uneven, so remedies are unreliable. And a **suspension is not a burial** — Base Toliara was suspended, not permanently killed, and mining pressure continues — so wins can be partial and reversible. So aim for what this lever can deliver — a mine halted, a company driven out, a project suspended — through a refusal that will not break and attention a government cannot ignore.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A mine with a government license and a foreign company behind it looks unstoppable, but it depends on being able to operate on land where people live — and a community that will not be moved, and draws the world's eyes, is a chain's weakest link made strong. A Malagasy fight turns on the **sustained refusal**; on **national and international attention**; on the **provenance of the license**; on the **land-and-livelihood case**; and on the **courts** where they function. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and a disciplined

refusal that will not break, watched by the nation and the world, is the one that drove a company out of Soamahamanina. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull — and weigh every step against the risk.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months on this — and weigh the danger — work out your real situation:

- **If a project sits on your land and livelihoods, a disciplined refusal is real power** — Soamahamanina's weekly marches drove out a foreign company.
- **If you can draw national and international eyes, they magnify and shield you** — the arrests at Soamahamanina brought a UN rapporteur.
- **If the license's provenance is shaky, that's a real vulnerability** — Base Toliara rested on a permit from a coup-born regime.
- **But know the risks and the limits** — defenders have met tear gas and arrest, institutions are weak, and a suspension can be reversed.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **build a refusal so disciplined and sustained it cannot be broken or ignored**, and **draw the national and international attention that magnifies it and shields the people in it** — while weighing every step against a real risk.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and where its weak points are.

Who Actually Decides

Formally the **government** grants mining licenses and drives projects, and its institutions are weak and its rule of law uneven. But a project must **operate on land where people live**, and a **community's sustained refusal** can force a government's hand, as at Soamahamanina. **National and international attention** — the press, the UN, human-rights and environmental bodies — presses the government from outside. The **provenance of a license** — who issued it, under what regime, on what terms — is a real vulnerability. And the **courts**, where they function, can be tried. Know which of these you can reach.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The operation on the ground. The project must work on the community's land. *Your opening — the decisive one:* a sustained, disciplined refusal that will not be moved.

The attention. *Your opening:* national and international eyes — press, the UN, human-rights bodies — that magnify and shield.

The license. *Your opening:* the question of its provenance and terms, especially from an illegitimate or transitional regime.

The courts. *Your opening, where they function:* a legal challenge.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things — carefully. **Who holds the license and how it was granted** — the company, the regime that issued it, the terms — because a shaky provenance is a real vulnerability, as with Base Toliara. **What land and livelihoods it takes** — the fields, the ancestral ground, the water — the case that unites a community. **Who is watching** — the national press, the UN, human-rights and environmental bodies —

because their attention magnifies a refusal and shields the people in it.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. **National and international press** carries a fight to the country and the world. **UN human-rights rapporteurs** and **human-rights and environmental bodies** watch and pressure, as a rapporteur came to Soamahamanina. The **courts**, where they function, can be tried. And Madagascar's **communities themselves**, with their sustained refusal, are the force that drove a company out — used with care, given the risks.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly — and weigh the danger. These are rough patterns, not promises, in a poor country with weak institutions where defenders have faced repression. What most moves them: the discipline and endurance of the refusal, and the attention it draws.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost / risk	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low–mod	The base for everything else
A sustained, disciplined refusal	35–60%	months–yr	real risk	A company driven out (Soamahamanina)
Draw national + international attention	35–60%	weeks–mo	mod	Magnifies and shields (a UN rapporteur)
Challenge the license's provenance	25–50%	months–yr	mod	A project's legitimacy in doubt
The land-and-livelihood case	30–55%	months	low–mod	A community united and heard
Court challenge (where functional)	15–40%	months–yr	mod	A decision delayed or quashed
Everything together	40–65%	months–yr	real risk	A mine halted, a company gone
Making a suspension permanent	harder	years	mod	Suspensions can be reversed

The levers that move the needle most are a **sustained, disciplined refusal** and the **national and international attention** it draws, backed by the **provenance challenge** and the **land case**.

Soamahamanina shows the ceiling (a foreign company driven out, a government forced to halt a mine) and the honest floor (defenders met tear gas and arrest, institutions are weak, and Base Toliara was suspended, not buried). So aim for a mine halted, a company driven out, a project suspended, or a license challenged — through a refusal that will not break, weighed always against the risk.

On cost: the greatest cost is not money but discipline, endurance, and risk. Sustaining a weekly refusal in the face of tear gas and arrests demands unity and courage; drawing attention demands care. The great strength is that a community that will not be moved, watched by the world, can force even a poor and uneven state to act; the honest limit is the danger, the weak institutions, and the reversibility of a suspension.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the mine" is weak. Being specific — this license, this provenance, this land — is strong. Answer five questions in writing, carefully.

1. What is it, who holds it, and how was it granted? Name the project, the company, and — crucially — **how the license was issued**: by what government, under what regime, on what terms. **A shaky provenance is a real vulnerability**, as Base Toliara's coup-era license was.

2. What land and livelihoods does it take? The **fields, the ancestral ground, the water** — the case that united Soamahamanina.

3. What is the risk, and how do you refuse safely? Assess the danger — defenders have met tear gas and arrest — and plan a refusal disciplined and sustained enough to endure it.

4. Who will watch? The **national and international press, the UN, human-rights and environmental bodies** — the attention that magnifies a refusal and shields the people in it.

5. Who's your community? The residents whose land and livelihoods are at stake — the unity that is the whole source of the power.

What this looks like in real life. A foreign company holds a license to mine land a community has farmed for generations. The five questions yield: the company and the license's provenance (a possible vulnerability); the fields and ancestral ground it takes; a hard read of the risk; the press and the UN as watchers; and a community to unite. That's the Soamahamanina pattern — a disciplined, sustained refusal, drawing national and international attention, weighed against the danger.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a refusal that endures and one that scatters is proof — and unity. Build it in three layers, carefully.

Layer one: the license and its provenance. Document **who holds the license, how it was granted, by what regime, on what terms** — because a shaky provenance is a real vulnerability, as Base Toliara's was.

Layer two: the land and livelihoods. Document the **land, the fields, the ancestral ground, the water** the project takes — the case that unites a community and moves the watching world.

Layer three: the harm and the risk. Document the **harm** the project does, and the **repression** defenders face — the tear gas, the arrests — safely, because this evidence draws the national and international attention that magnifies and shields. Walking to the press, the UN, and human-rights bodies with a documented land case and a documented refusal is what forced a government's hand at Soamahamanina.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The license and its provenance** — who holds it, how and by whom it was granted, on what terms.
- **The land and livelihoods** — the fields, the ancestral ground, the water taken.
- **The harm** — the environmental and human damage.
- **The repression** — the tear gas, the arrests, documented safely.
- **The watchers** — the press, the UN, human-rights and environmental bodies to reach.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a community united in a disciplined, sustained refusal gives you the power that drove a company out of Soamahamanina. Build in four moves, carefully.

Root it in the land and its people. Soamahamanina's power was its unity — a whole farming community, refusing together, over the land and graves of generations. Root the effort there, in the place and the people and what the land means.

Make the refusal disciplined and sustained. The lever was a refusal that would not break — every Thursday, week after week, through tear gas and arrests. Build a refusal disciplined enough to endure, and unity strong enough that arrests of leaders do not scatter it.

Draw the attention that magnifies and shields. The decisive multiplier: national and international attention — the press, a UN rapporteur, human-rights bodies — which turned local marches into a national and international cause and shielded the people in them. Reach the watchers early.

Protect people and build to last. Given the real risk, plan for safety, protect leaders and members, build clear roles and a secure archive, and prepare for a long fight — and for the possibility that a win is a suspension that must be defended.

STEP 4: THE REFUSAL, THE ATTENTION & THE LICENSE

Madagascar's levers combine a community's refusal, the world's attention, and a project's shaky provenance.

The Sustained Refusal — the Decisive Lever

The Soamahamanina lever: a community's **sustained, disciplined refusal** — rooted in the land, unbroken by tear gas or arrests — that will not be moved. This is the source of the power; it drove a foreign company out and forced a government to halt a mine. Build a refusal that endures.

National and International Attention

The multiplier: **national and international attention** — the press, a **UN human-rights rapporteur**, human-rights and environmental bodies — which magnifies a refusal into a cause a government cannot ignore, and shields the people in it, as the arrests at Soamahamanina drew a rapporteur.

The License's Provenance and the Courts

The vulnerability: the **provenance of the license** — issued by an illegitimate or transitional regime, on unfavourable terms — which can be challenged, as Base Toliara's coup-era permit was. And the **courts**, where they function, can be tried.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: defenders here have met tear gas and arrest, so safety comes first; institutions are weak and the rule of law uneven, so remedies are unreliable; and a suspension is not a burial — Base Toliara was suspended, not killed, and mining pressure continues. So use the levers — the refusal, the attention, the provenance challenge — weigh every step against the danger, and count a mine halted, a company driven out, a project suspended, or a license challenged as wins, while being ready to defend them.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Land becomes a refusal. Not a plea but a fact: *"this is the land our families have farmed and been buried in for generations — we will not give it up,"* as Soamahamanina refused.

A license becomes a question of legitimacy. *"This permit was granted by a coup-born regime on terms unfavourable to the people,"* as with Base Toliara.

Repression becomes a case for the world. *"They met peaceful marchers with tear gas and arrests — the world should see this,"* as it drew a UN rapporteur.

A project becomes a private deal against the people. *"This serves a foreign company, not the community whose land it takes."*

Match it to the venue: the refusal to the ground and the public; the land and repression to the national and international press and the UN; the license's provenance to the courts and the government; the whole case to human-rights and environmental bodies.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Madagascar, attention is the decisive multiplier — national and international eyes turned Soamahamanina's local marches into a cause a government had to answer, and shielded the marchers. Drawing that attention is the media strategy.

Lead with the land, the people, and the repression, not procedure. "A whole farming community, marching every week over the land of their ancestors, met with tear gas — and refusing to stop." Use your strongest material: the ancestral land, the disciplined refusal, and the repression it met.

Work the national and international audiences at once. National press builds the cause; international attention — the UN, human-rights and environmental bodies, the world's media — presses the government and shields the people, as a rapporteur came to Soamahamanina. Make it easy: clear, verified evidence, and safely-gathered testimony and images.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit a cause and endanger people. And protect people first — never publish what could expose someone to greater repression.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; protect identities; keep copies secure.

8A — To a UN human-rights rapporteur / body.

Subject: Land defenders at risk — [place], Madagascar.

"We report that [project] threatens our land and livelihoods, and that peaceful opposition has met [tear gas/arrests]: [specifics, safely stated]. We ask your attention and protection, as a rapporteur attended Soamahamanina. [Secure contact.]"

8B — To the national / international press.

Subject: A farming community refusing a mine on its ancestral land.

"[Project] would mine [land our families have farmed for generations]. We march peacefully and refuse, and have met [repression]. We can provide verified evidence and testimony. [Secure contact.]"

8C — Challenging the license's provenance.

Subject: The legitimacy of [project]'s license.

"We record that [project]'s license was granted by [regime/circumstances] on [terms]: [specifics]. We ask that its legitimacy be examined, as with Base Toliara. [Contact.]"

8D — Court challenge (to a lawyer, where courts function).

Subject: Legal challenge — [project].

"We seek to challenge [project]'s [license/permit]: [grounds, incl. provenance]. We ask your advice. [Secure contact and evidence summary.]"

8E — To a human-rights / environmental organisation.

Subject: Support a community facing [project].

"We, the community of [place], face [project and its harms and repression]. We ask your support and attention. [Secure contact.]"

8F — To the government authority.

Subject: Opposition to [project] at [place].

"We are the community of [place] opposing [project], which takes our land and livelihoods on [a questionable license]. We ask that it be halted, as Soamahamanina's was. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Recording the community's refusal.

Subject: We do not consent — [project].

"We, the community of [place], record that we do not consent to [project] on our land: [specifics]. [Contact, as safe.]"

8H — Sustaining the community.

Subject: Our land — let's not be moved.

"[Project] takes our land. Soamahamanina marched every week and drove a company out. Let's refuse together, draw the world's eyes, and keep each other safe. [Secure contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order — weighing the risk:

- 1. Unite the community in a disciplined, sustained refusal (8G/8H).**
- 2. Document the land, the harm, and any repression, safely.**

3. **Draw national and international attention — press, the UN (8A/8B).**
4. **Challenge the license's provenance and terms (8C).**
5. **Try the courts where they function (8D).**
6. **Reach human-rights and environmental bodies for support and shield (8E).**

Even lean, those six build a refusal and draw the eyes that magnify it — the Soamahamanina template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Madagascar's field is tilted by weak institutions, poverty, and real repression, so plan for it.

When defenders face repression. Peaceful marchers have met tear gas and arrest. Plan for safety, protect leaders and members, build a refusal disciplined enough to endure arrests without scattering, and draw the international attention that shields.

When institutions are weak. The rule of law is uneven and remedies unreliable. Lean on the sustained refusal, the national and international attention, and the provenance challenge, which reach past weak institutions.

When a license is shaky. A permit from a transitional or coup-born regime, on unfavourable terms, is a real vulnerability, as Base Toliara's was — challenge its legitimacy.

When a win is only a suspension. Base Toliara was suspended, not killed. Treat a suspension as a win to be defended — keep the community, the attention, and the pressure alive against a reversal.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Madagascar's mining deals — a foreign company handed a forty-year license over a community's ancestral land, or a permit issued by a coup-born regime on unfavourable terms — are often shadowed by corruption and connected interests, so this matters; but expose it carefully.

How to spot it. Licenses granted by illegitimate or transitional regimes; sweeping concessions over communities' land on terms unfavourable to the people and the state; a project driven despite local opposition; benefits to a foreign company and connected interests while communities lose land and livelihoods.

Who's supposed to guard against it. Given weak domestic institutions, the real watchers are often the **national and international press, UN rapporteurs, and human-rights and environmental bodies** — and, where they function, the **courts**. The provenance and terms of a license are themselves grounds to challenge.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the license's provenance and terms, who benefits, the harm — protecting identities; route serious evidence to the press, the UN, and trusted organisations through secure channels, since these often reach further than weak domestic institutions. Keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect, and never let exposure endanger anyone.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, and safely. The land case unites the community; the sustained refusal is the power; the national and international attention magnifies and shields it; the provenance challenge undermines the license; the courts can be tried. Together they multiply. One at a time, they scatter — and every step must be weighed against the risk.

Early on (weeks): unite the community; document the land, the license's provenance, and any harm; identify the watchers to reach.

In the thick of it (weeks–months): sustain the disciplined refusal; draw national and international attention; challenge the license; try the courts where they function.

The long haul (months–years): hold the refusal and the attention until the government acts, as at Soamahamanina; then defend the win — a suspension is not a burial — and keep people safe throughout.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Madagascar can be done, even by a poor farming community against a foreign company and a government at once — Soamahamanina marched every week over the land of its ancestors, refused through tear gas and arrests, drew the eyes of the nation and a UN rapporteur, and drove the company out. Hold both truths. Madagascar's distinctive power is real: a community's sustained, disciplined refusal, rooted in its land and livelihoods and magnified by national and international attention, can force even a weak and uneven state to halt a mine — and the shaky provenance of a license, issued by an illegitimate or transitional regime, is a real vulnerability to press. And the constraints are real: defenders have met tear gas and arrest, so safety must come first; institutions are weak and remedies unreliable; and a win can be a suspension, not a burial — Base Toliara was suspended, not killed, and mining pressure continues.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won. Root the fight in the land and livelihoods, and build a refusal so disciplined and sustained it cannot be broken or ignored — the weekly, unbroken refusal that drove a company out of Soamahamanina. Draw the national and international attention — the press, a UN rapporteur, human-rights and environmental bodies — that magnifies that refusal into a cause a government must answer, and shields the people in it. Challenge the provenance and terms of a shaky license, as with Base Toliara. Try the courts where they function. Weigh every step against a real danger, and protect people first. Count a mine halted, a company driven out, a project suspended, or a license challenged as wins — and be ready to defend them, because a suspension is not a burial. That is how Soamahamanina won — a refusal that would not break, watched by the world. So can you.